

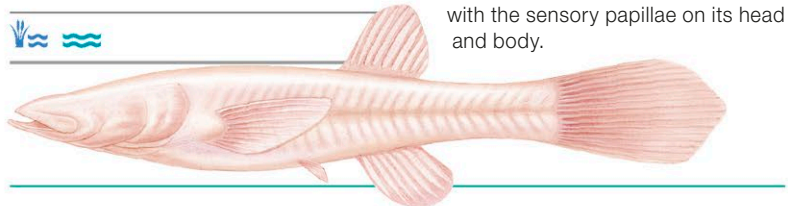
Amblyopsis spelaea

Northern cavefish



Length Up to 4¼ in (10.5 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Near threatened

Location USA (Kentucky, Indiana)



Like most cave-dwelling fishes, the northern cavefish has pale skin, is completely blind—in this case only vestigial eye tissues remaining under the skin—and has a very localized distribution. It is restricted to the limestone caves straddling the state line between Kentucky and Indiana, an area of less than 40 square miles (100 sq km). It feeds on tiny, cave-dwelling invertebrates, detecting them with the sensory papillae on its head and body.

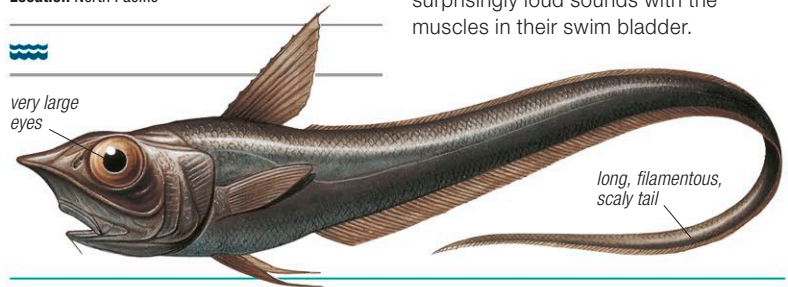
Coryphaenoides acrolepis

Pacific grenadier



Length Up to 39 in (1 m)
Weight Up to 22 lb (10 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

Location North Pacific



Also known as rattails or whiptails, grenadiers are the dominant fishes on the sloping edges of the world's continental shelves. Like its 400 or so relatives, the Pacific grenadier has a large, bulbous head, a sharp snout, and a body that tapers rapidly into a narrow tail. Its eyes are large, enabling it to see prey on the seabed. The males make surprisingly loud sounds with the muscles in their swim bladder.

Merluccius productus

Pacific hake



Length Up to 35 in (90 cm)
Weight Up to 11 lb (5 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location North Pacific



Closely related to the Atlantic cod (see below), the Pacific hake has a similar shape, with an elongated body, large head, and projecting lower jaw. It is bluish gray on its back, and silvery on its sides. Much like the Atlantic cod, it forms large schools and spawns in early spring, when the females lay millions of eggs. These drift near the surface and are widely distributed by ocean currents. Eaten by marine animals such as porpoises, seals, and swordfishes, the Pacific hake has been and is still heavily fished by humans.

Gadus morhua

Atlantic cod



Length Up to 4½ ft (1.4 m)
Weight Up to 55 lb (25 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Vulnerable

Location North Atlantic, Arctic Ocean



This large, school-forming fish is one of the world's most commercially important species. It lives in water over the continental

shelf, and usually feeds at 100–250 ft (30–80 m) above areas of flat mud or sand and catches prey both from the seabed and in mid-water. Other fishes, especially herrings, sprats, and capelin, form its main prey. It usually breeds in early spring, with females releasing millions of eggs into the water. Adult cod migrate extensively and keep together, making them relatively easy to catch.



Zeus faber

John Dory

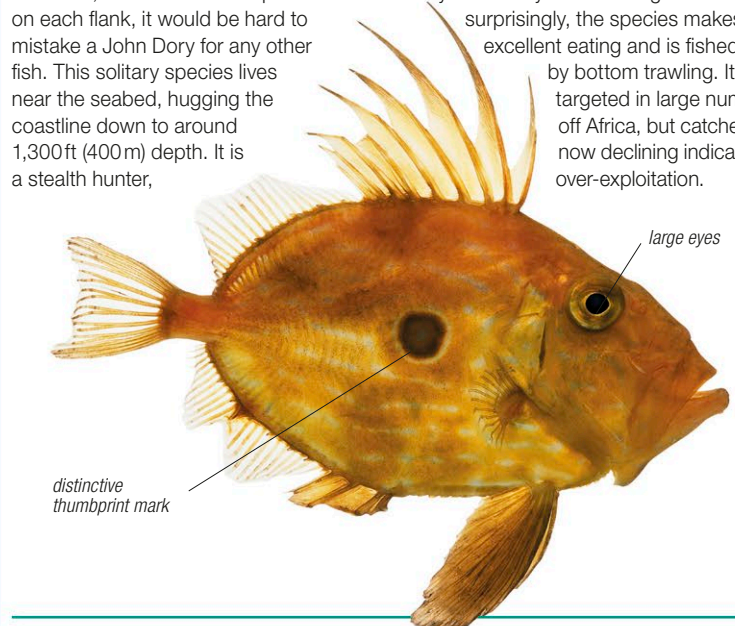


Length Up to 30 in (90 cm)
Weight Up to 18 lb (8 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Data deficient

Location E. Atlantic, Mediterranean, Indian Ocean, W., S.W. Pacific



With its dinner-plate shape; tall, spiny dorsal fin; and black “thumbprint” mark on each flank, it would be hard to mistake a John Dory for any other fish. This solitary species lives near the seabed, hugging the coastline down to around 1,300 ft (400 m) depth. It is a stealth hunter,



approaching its prey head-on and very slowly. In this position its ultra-thin body is nearly invisible, and once within striking range it shoots its tubelike jaws forward and sucks in small fish and crustaceans. Rather like freshwater pikes (p.501), it can hang almost motionless in the water but can dart away at speed if threatened by predators, such as sharks and other large fish. During spawning, females scatter their eggs in batches onto the seabed, where they are fertilized by the males. When they hatch, the tiny larvae swim and drift as they develop in the plankton. John Dory can live for up to 15 or so years if they are not caught. Perhaps surprisingly, the species makes excellent eating and is fished by bottom trawling. It is targeted in large numbers off Africa, but catches are now declining indicating over-exploitation.

Lota lota

Burbot



Length Up to 4 ft (1.2 m)
Weight Up to 75 lb (34 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location N. North America, Europe, N. Asia



This long, slender fish is the only cod to spend the whole of its life in freshwater. It is usually a dull, dirty green to brown above, with dark mottling, and yellowish to creamy below. The fish hides under tree roots or in crevices by day, and is most active at dawn and dusk, when it hunts for insect larvae, crustaceans, and other fishes. It spawns in winter, and does so—unlike most other fishes—in the middle of the night, and often under the ice.

CONSERVATION

The Atlantic cod has been heavily harvested for many years. In the 19th century, specimens of up to 200 lb (90 kg) were sometimes caught, but with today's sophisticated fishing techniques, stocks have shrunk dramatically; fishes weighing over 33 lb (15 kg) are rare.



FULL-BODIED

A long-bodied fish, the Atlantic cod has a bluntly pointed snout, with one barbel hanging from its lower jaw. Coloration ranges from greenish to sandy brown.